

OpenClaw Setup: Zero to Running

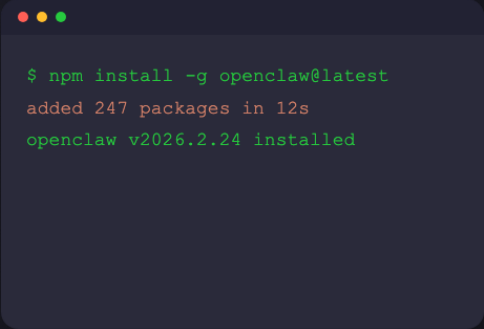
Part 2 of the OpenClaw series. You've seen what it can do. Now let's get it running on your machine. 10 minutes. That's all it takes.

What You Need

- 01** Node.js 18+ installed on your system
- 02** An API key (Claude, OpenAI, or DeepSeek)
- 03** A messaging app (WhatsApp, Telegram, etc.)
- 04** Terminal access (Mac, Linux, or WSL on Windows)

Step 1: Install

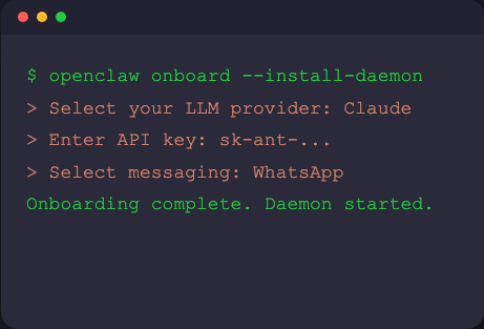
One command to install globally.
This gives you the openclaw CLI.



```
$ npm install -g openclaw@latest  
added 247 packages in 12s  
openclaw v2026.2.24 installed
```


Step 2: Onboard

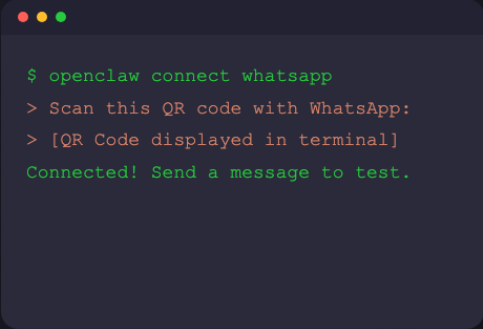
The onboard wizard walks you through API keys, messaging setup, and daemon config.



```
$ openclaw onboard --install-daemon
> Select your LLM provider: Claude
> Enter API key: sk-ant-...
> Select messaging: WhatsApp
Onboarding complete. Daemon started.
```

Step 3: Connect Messaging

Scan a QR code or paste a token.
OpenClaw now lives in your chat app.



```
$ openclaw connect whatsapp  
> Scan this QR code with WhatsApp:  
> [QR Code displayed in terminal]  
Connected! Send a message to test.
```

Docker vs NPM Install

BEFORE

- ✗ NPM: Simple install, low resources
- ✗ Best for personal machines
- ✗ Easy debugging and iteration
- ✗ Quick start for experimentation

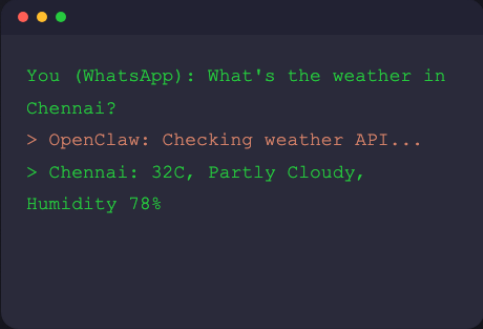


AFTER

- ✓ Docker: Container isolation
- ✓ Best for VPS / always-on setups
- ✓ Consistent environment across machines
- ✓ Production-grade for serious use

Step 4: Test It

Send your first message.
Watch it think, plan, and execute.



```
You (WhatsApp): What's the weather in  
Chennai?  
> OpenClaw: Checking weather API...  
> Chennai: 32C, Partly Cloudy,  
Humidity 78%
```


Pro Tips for Setup

- Use Docker for always-on server deployments
- Start with Claude as your LLM (best agent performance)
- Connect multiple messaging apps simultaneously
- Set up cron jobs for automated daily summaries

Follow for Part 3!



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